Table 12.1 Different types of Silkworm

Species of silkmoth	Silk Producing States	Preferred Food (Leaves)	Type Of Silk
Bombyx mori	Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu	Mulberry	Mulberry Silk
Antheraea assamensis	Assam, Meghalaya. Nagaland, Arunachala Pradesh and Manipur	Champa	Muga Silk
Antheraea mylitta	West Bengal, Bihar and Jharkand	Arjun	Tassar Silk
Attacus ricini	Assam, Meghalaya. Nagaland, Arunachala Pradesh and Manipur	Castor	Eri Silk

scale is called sericulture. It is an agro-based industry comprising three main components: i) cultivation of food plants for the silkworms, ii) rearing of silkworms, and iii) reeling and spinning of silk. The first two are agricultural and the last one is an industrial component. Only few species of silkworms are used in the sericulture industry (Table 12. 1 and Figure 12. 2).

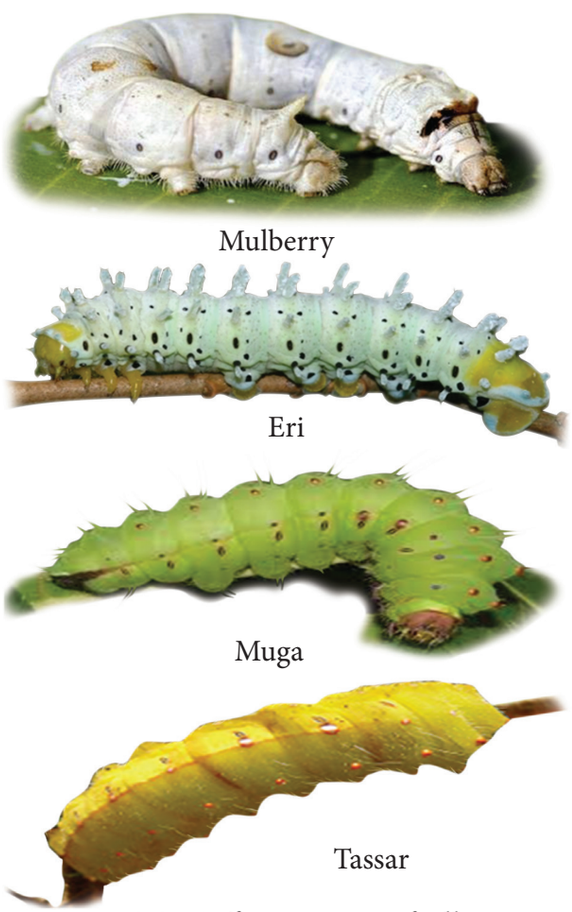


Figure 12.2 Different types of silkworms

Life cycle of *Bombyx mori*

The adult of *Bombyx mori* is about 2.5 cm in length and pale creamy white in colour. Due to heavy body and feeble wings, flight is not possible by the female moth. This moth is unisexual in nature and does not feed during its very short life period of 2-3 days. Just after emergence, male moth copulates with female for about 2-3 hours and if not separated, they may die after few hours of copulating with female. Just after copulation, female starts egg laying which is completed in1-24 hours. A single female moth lays 400 to 500 eggs depending upon the climatic conditions. Two types of eggs are generally found namely diapause type and non-diapause type. The diapause type is laid by silkworms inhabiting the temperate regions, whereas silkworms belonging to subtropical regions like India lay non-diapause type of eggs. The eggs after ten days of incubation hatch into larva called as caterpillar. The newly hatched caterpillar is

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